Day 15 - Norman Pearson, Eric Best, King, McNally, Smokey Hollow

Bruce Trail side-trail plan (dog-friendly, max ~8 mi) · Iroquoia section · hike 21 · Great Falls (Smokey Hollow), Waterdown

10.4 km / 6.5 mi	~3.2 h	3.5 km new	45 min
total walking	hiking, plus stops	side trail covered	drive each way, Sat 7 am

Park (P): Great Falls: Parking area beside Mill St, at the Smokey Hollow Side Trail. Google Maps. **Free**

Navigate: import *day15_hike021.gpx* into Gaia GPS. The track is the whole route in walking order, and the J waypoints match the directions below.

Side trails covered: Norman Pearson Side Trail (1.4 km); Eric Best Side Trail (1.0 km); King Side Trail (0.6 km); McNally Side Trail (0.5 km); Smokey Hollow Side Trail (0.1 km)

Route map



What to expect

- **Parking:** Lot beside Mill St at the Smokey Hollow Side Trail, right by the falls (a trip report describes it as free).
- **Great Falls:** About 10 m high on Grindstone Creek, with an overhanging dolostone cap and remains of an old mill dam and stone abutments. The Smokey Hollow Side Trail leads to a viewing platform above the crest. The creek banks get slippery and icy; stay back from the edge.
- **Main Bruce Trail:** Steps and switchbacks on the Grindstone Creek valley slopes near the falls, and several short road-shoulder stretches (including Flanders Dr); keep Zappy close. A lookout past King Rd gives views of Burlington and Lake Ontario.
- **Norman Pearson and McNally side trails:** The Norman Pearson Side Trail (blue-blazed) runs from level ground on the main trail to Waterdown Rd, including a road stretch. It connects to the McNally Side Trail, which crosses BTC-owned land with a reported overlook of

Burlington Bay and tall trees along the escarpment edge.

- **Eric Best and King side trails:** No specific descriptions were found. Around King Rd the main trail passes through Conservation Halton's Waterdown Woods: a grassy field and mature hardwoods.
- **Private land:** Much of the trail here crosses private property by landowner permission. Stay on the marked trail.

Parking options

	Alternative parking	Parking cost	Route km	Walk to trail	Closest side trails
P2	Roadside parking on King Rd map	Free	4.3	0 m	

Can't do it all in one go? Split it into two shorter outings: **Outing 1** from the planned parking (P): 3.8 km / 2.4 mi, covering McNally, Norman Pearson, Smokey Hollow. **Outing 2** from P2 (Roadside parking on King Rd; Free): 7.9 km / 4.9 mi, covering Eric Best, King. The website's map shows which parts are already done.

Parking costs were checked in October 2026 from operator websites and Bruce Trail Conservancy data; prices and booking rules change, so check before you go.

Turn-by-turn

km	mi	Directions
0.0	0.0	Start at the parking: Great Falls: Parking area beside Mill St, at the Smokey Hollow Side Trail. Head south on the blue-blazed Smokey Hollow Side Trail.
0.1	0.0	J1: Continue straight onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south-east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.)
0.8	0.5	J2: Turn left onto the blue-blazed Norman Pearson Side Trail, heading east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
1.2	0.7	Heads-up: The next 0.1 km follows an unopened road allowance (rough track, no traffic).
1.3	0.8	Heads-up: The next 0.4 km follows a road shoulder; keep the dog close.
2.1	1.3	J3: Continue straight onto the blue-blazed McNally Side Trail, heading east. (the blue-blazed McNally Side Trail goes off on your left.)
2.3	1.4	J4: End of the McNally Side Trail. Turn around and retrace your steps.
2.4	1.5	J3: Junction. Turn right to stay on the McNally Side Trail, heading north-west. (the Norman Pearson Side Trail you already walked goes off ahead.)
2.8	1.7	J5: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
4.8	3.0	J6: Turn left onto the blue-blazed King Side Trail, heading north. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
5.4	3.4	J7: Turnaround point. Turn around and retrace your steps.
6.0	3.7	J6: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south-west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.)
8.1	5.0	J5: Junction. Turn right to stay on the main Bruce Trail, heading north-west. (the McNally Side Trail you already walked goes off on your left.)
8.2	5.1	Heads-up: The next 0.4 km follows a road shoulder; keep the dog close.
8.7	5.4	J8: Turn right onto the blue-blazed Eric Best Side Trail, heading south. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your left.)
9.0	5.6	J9: Start the Eric Best Side Trail loop (0.6 km). Continue straight onto it, heading north-east; it brings you back to this junction.
10.0	6.2	J8: Turn right onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading east. (the main Bruce Trail you already walked goes off on your left.)
10.4	6.4	J1: Turn right onto the blue-blazed Smokey Hollow Side Trail, heading north-west. (the main Bruce Trail you already walked goes off on your left.)
10.4	6.5	Back at the parking. Hike complete.

Distances and junctions are computed from the Bruce Trail Conservancy's trail data (Bruce County GIS). Left/right is calculated from the trail geometry. Use it as a guide, follow the blazes, and check the Conservancy's trail-change notices before you go. Dogs must be leashed everywhere on the Bruce Trail. Trail descriptions draw on Hiking the GTA, Ontario Nature Trails and a 2015 Bruce Trail trip report.